MODULE 1 · CFIT AWARENESS AND PREVENTION

Lesson 03: ATC, Complacency and Crew Alertness

Lesson 3 of 7 · about 6 min

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Challenge clearances that conflict with terrain awareness.
- Recognise complacency on familiar routes.
- Use briefings and callouts to keep terrain awareness.



Challenge clearances that do not fit your terrain picture.

Working with ATC

- **You are responsible for terrain clearance** — including when accepting an altitude clearance.
- **Challenge or refuse** ATC instructions that are not clearly understood, are questionable, or conflict with your own assessment of the aircraft's position relative to terrain.
- Use standard phraseology and good radio discipline. Read back every clearance so that everyone agrees on its content.
- Do not accept unreasonable clearances, such as a descent that does not fit the terrain or the approach.
- Use the autopilot mode that makes compliance with the ATC instruction easiest and most visible.

Complacency

- Familiarity can lead to complacency. **Do not assume this flight will be like the last one.**
- Keep a professional attitude, even at an aerodrome you know well.
- Brief the operational differences: NOTAMs, inoperative aids, a different runway, the weather.

Briefings and callouts

- Terrain awareness is a primary reason for briefings and callouts. Both pilots must share a common understanding of what to expect.
- Brief the MSA, the highest terrain, the approach and missed approach, and the escape route.
- Call out FMA and FMS changes, deviations from the path, and undesirable energy states.

WARNING

During an approach in IMC, fly the **published IFR approach procedure only**. Do not improvise.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The crew is responsible for terrain clearance — challenge doubtful clearances.
- Familiarity breeds complacency; brief the differences every time.
- Brief MSA, terrain and escape route; call out FMA changes and deviations.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

ATC clears you to descend to an altitude below the MSA, but you are not yet established on the approach and are unsure of your position. What do you do?

A. Descend as cleared

B. Question the clearance and do not descend until your position and terrain clearance are confirmed

C. Descend at a low rate

D. Ask the cabin crew to look outside

Answer: B. The crew is responsible for terrain clearance. Challenge any clearance that conflicts with your terrain awareness.

Training material only. It does not replace the Aircraft Flight Manual, FCOM, QRH, MEL or the Domestic Airlines Operations Manual, which always take precedence.